the Soviet-brokered Tashkent Agreement, which officially ended the 1965 war, both sides agreed in January 1966 to return to the status quo ante and to renounce the use of force in settling future disputes.[22]

One of the unanticipated outcomes of the 1965 Kashmir conflict was the growth of Bengali separatism in East Pakistan. The Pakistani military had long contended that the “defense of the east lay in the west” and so they chose not to deploy significant firepower in East Pakistan during the war. The Bengali population of East Pakistan realized that they had emerged mostly unscathed from the war thanks not to the Pakistani military, but rather to India’s sufferance. Within less than a decade, their growing dissatisfaction with West Pakistani dominance would culminate in a civil war and contribute to the third Indio-Pakistani conflict, the 1971 Bangladesh war.[23] The Bangladesh war radically altered the region’s territorial division and created the conventional military environment that has largely continued until today.

When Pakistan held its first national election in October 1970, the Bengali Awami League won a majority of seats in the National Assembly. But the League’s demands for greater Bengali autonomy concerned Pakistani president Yahya Khan, who did not permit Awami League leader Mujibur Rehman to form a government. And Pakistan People’s Party leader Zulfikar Ali Bhutto called for new elections, refusing to share power with Rehman. In response, large-scale rioting erupted in East Pakistan. West Pakistani troops, deployed to quash the violence, exacerbated the situation, slaughtering large numbers of intellectuals, Awami League members, and Hindus. Pakistan descended into civil war.[24]

These events unleashed a flood of refugees. Millions of East Pakistanis crossed the border into India to escape the violence, quickly exceeding India’s capacity to absorb them. The Indians therefore sought to the stop the civil war by severing East and West Pakistan. To that end, in October and November, India began backing East Pakistani rebel forces, known as Mukti Bahini (literally “liberation force”). Pakistan retaliated on December 3 by launching air strikes against Indian air bases. This triggered a full-scale war. India attacked East Pakistan with six army divisions, rapidly